

MGTF417: Professional Communication in Finance

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Lecturer: Robert Schmidt

rpschmidt@ucsd.edu

Office hours: by appointment

Teaching Assistant: Dylan Schuman

Dylan.Schuman@rady.ucsd.edu

Office hours: by appointment

DESCRIPTION

Many employers in diverse industries are disappointed with college graduates' writing skills; the disappointment can be especially true in finance-related careers where dependence on data and statistics when communicating can mask, rather than illuminate, key messages. While writing style can be subjective, there are basic principles students can learn and use to build expertise when writing about finance-related topics. Professional Communication in Finance focuses on these principles, their practical application and writing as critical inquiry and creative force. Beyond writing, this class also provides guidance for effective communication when speaking.

While AI tools such as ChatGPT have proven beneficial to assist with creating slides, written reports and helping with presenting, they should not be a substitute for learning, problem assessment and human judgment. In this course, students may use AI tools, but must attribute where and how they were used. In addition, students may be asked to explain the key assumptions AI may have used in its creative process. The goal? Sharpen students' critical thinking and help better prepare them for working with AI—not using AI as a replacement for one of the greatest attributes students will bring to the workforce: their ideas; their goals; and their unique voices.

Clear writing and speaking reflect clear thinking; clear writing and speaking deliver ideas and incite action. Writing talent flows not from inspiration, but from disciplined application, nurtured with time and guidance. Anyone with a basic grasp of English can enhance her/his writing ability. Students will work collaboratively and independently to sharpen their talents, focusing on how data and text can complement and strengthen key messages conveyed in written reports. Students also will learn basics of business journalism which will help shape research questions and underscore the importance of simple, straightforward prose.

This course will help prepare students for a range of communication tasks they may face on the job. In addition, the course will ask students to reflect on their research and writing processes and challenge them to view themselves as writers so they may add to the critical conversation in their chosen fields. Students will learn to question assumptions, guard against bias, explore, explain, analyze, develop, and critique ideas effectively and make appropriate decisions about argument, structure, and rhetorical conventions. The course consists of lectures that build upon required reading, group discussion, and individual and group writing and speaking projects. The course is built on a simple foundation of four verbs designed to enhance communication ability. These verbs are easy to remember with the acronym: RACE.

1. **Research:** good writing reflects solid investigation, data gathering and striving to understand.
2. **Analyze:** apply critical questions to data and transform it into information the audience can use.
3. **Communicate:** deliver key points with text and complementary graphics (charts, tables, etc.)
4. **Edit:** high-quality writing projects aren't created once; they are re-written, re-created, revised and polished.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of Professional Communication in Finance, students will be able to:

- Structure Persuasive Arguments When Writing and Speaking
- Attract and Keep an Audience's Attention—When Writing and Speaking
- Distinguish Facts from Assumptions in Written, Finance-Related Research
- Work Better as a Team Member on Communication-Based Projects
- Form Insightful Research Queries, Limit Bias and Attribute Facts Properly
- Apply Tables and Graphics to Complement Text, Whether in Reports or PowerPoint Slides
- Follow Basics of FINRA Rules on “Advertising” to Avoid Legal/Compliance Issues
- Employ RACE Principles to Enhance Communication Skill After this Class

MATERIALS

Required

- Damodaran, Aswath. “Narrative and Numbers.” New York: Columbia Business School Publishing. 2017.

Recommended

- Associated Press. *The Associated Press Stylebook*. 39th ed. Cambridge, MA: Basic Books, 2004.
- Booth, Wayne C., Gregory G. Colomb and Joseph M. Williams. *The Craft of Research*. 3rd ed. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2008.
- Gallo, Carmine. *Talk Like TED: The 9 Public-Speaking Secrets of the World's Top Minds*. New York: St. Martin's Griffin. 2014.
- Garner, Bryan A. *HBR Guide to Better Business Writing*. Boston: Harvard Business School Publishing, 2012.
- Maxwell, John C. *The 16 Undeniable Laws of Communication*. Maxwell Publishing, 2023.
- May, Claire B. and Gordon S. May. *Effective Writing: A Handbook for Accountants*. 10th Ed. Boston: Pearson Publishing. 2015.
- Miller, Jane E. *The Chicago Guide to Writing About Numbers*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2004.
- Patterson, Kerry, Joseph Grenny, Ron McMillan and Al Switzler. *Crucial Conversations: Tools for Talking When Stakes Are High*. Second Edition. New York: McGraw-Hill. 2012.
- Sonkin, Paul D. and Paul Johnson. *Pitch the Perfect Investment: The Essential Guide to Winning on Wall Street*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley Press. 2017.
- Tufte, Edward. *The Visual Display of Quantitative Information*. Cheshire, Conn.: Graphics Press, 2001.

SCHEDULE

Date	Due	Class Topic & Activities	Assignments
Before First Class			1. Prepare to discuss Assignment 1 in class Week 1 2. Find your group members on Canvas (assigned specifically for this class). 3. Talk with group members and choose a project by picking one of these four stocks to analyze: Alibaba; Amazon; Ferrari; or Uber. Or, discuss how Finance can solve a vital issue.
Week 1	1. Be prepared to discuss Assignment 1	1. Information Interviews 2. Career Center 3. Course Overview 4. Andrew Lo: Finance Can Cure Cancer 5. Discuss Group Project	1. Read chapters 1-11 of the Damodaran text
Week 2		1. Behavioral Biases & Communication 2. Group Presentation Discussion 3. Structuring Your Argument 4. Tables, Charts and Text: Creating Slides 5. Importance of Diversity	1. Create slides for Group Project presentation 2. Read Chapters 12-16 of Damodaran text
Week 3	1. Slides for Group Project presentation	1. Compliance Issues 2. Enhancing Slides 3. Transitions & Paragraphs 4. Public Speaking Tactics 5. "Chatter"	1. Write Group Project report 2. Prepare for Group Project presentation
Week 4	1. Group Project report 2. Group Project Presentation	1. Group Project Presentations 2. Group Project Presentation Evaluation 3. Mechanics & Structure Issues	1. Revise and re-submit Group Project Written Report 2. Group Project Evaluation
Week 5	1. <u>Revised</u> Group Project Report 2. Group Project Presentation 3. Group Project Presentation Critique	1. Group Project Presentations 2. Group Project Evaluation 3. Course Evaluation 4. Final Exam Discussion	1. Group Project Evaluation

ASSIGNMENTS

Assignment 1: Before the start of the first class, think about these four questions. Write some notes and come to the first class prepared to tell others your thoughts.

1. What specific elements make communication effective when writing?
2. What specific traits make someone an exceptional public speaker?
3. What traits would you want in a person hired to help enhance your writing and public speaking skills?
4. Are communication skills important for MQF students AFTER graduation? Give at least one reason why these skills ARE important and one reason why they are NOT important.

**** Also, we will NOT discuss your answers to this next question in class, but write down a few words that describe “your authentic self.” If you had to sum up the essence of your personality, what 1, 2 or 3 words would you use?

Group Project:

You must deliver these things for credit on the group project:

- PowerPoint slides to accompany your presentation (≥ 10 slides and ≤ 20 slides)
- a written report of 800 to 1200 words with at least two graphics (charts and/or tables)
- an in-class presentation of at least 10 minutes, but not more than 15 minutes maximum. Each group member must speak for at least 1 minute.
- each group member must complete an evaluation of every speaker in *another* group’s presentation (you will be assigned which other group to evaluate)

Group Project Report:

Guidelines/Outline:

1. Executive Summary
 - Make this very brief (roughly 200 words)
 - If a reader only had 30-45 seconds to understand the key points from your research, what would you write?
2. Introduction
 - Why is this an interesting and challenging, yet feasible empirical problem?
 - Brief review of existing work in this area (if relevant)
 - Outline of the remaining parts of your project
3. Outline of the Empirical Question
 - Set up the problem: what is the issue and how will you address it?
 - How have others tackled the problem, if at all?
4. Data and Methodology
 - What are your data sources?
 - Describe your data
 - Describe how you conduct your analysis
5. Results
 - What did you find? What are the key conclusions?
 - How are your conclusions the same as and/or different vs. other experts (including AI tools such as ChatGPT or Bard)?

- How would you handle objections to your conclusion? What would you tell someone if they said, “You’re wrong.”

6. Evaluation and Conclusion

- Briefly re-state key findings.
- What are the practical applications?
- Are there other areas to research on this topic?

7. References (do not include with slides, just the written report)

- What academic or practitioner reports, articles, websites or books did you review that helped in your research?
- List them alphabetically by primary author’s last/family name.
- Give enough details so your reader could find the same report: author, title of the book or article, where published, date, link to a website

Your PowerPoint slides and Group Project written report can follow this same outline.

Group Project:

Pick one of these two options:

1. Value one of the following four companies analyzed in the Damodaran textbook: Uber; Alibaba; Amazon; or Ferrari. Tell your audience why the stock is either fairly valued, undervalued or over valued at its current price. Start with the data provided in the textbook and update it if necessary. To build your narrative, consider using one of the “Types of Business Stories” listed on page 31 of the Damodaran textbook.

2. Describe how finance/financial engineering might help improve a business, environmental or social issue. Suggested topics:

- a. reduce carbon emissions
- b. enhance recycling rates for plastics
- c. make insurance more accessible/affordable for homeowners in areas prone to fires
- d. improve access to fresh water in drought-prone areas
- e. enhance a sense of belonging for an underrepresented group within a community
- f. counter high prices for homes in a city or region
- g. bring a greater sense of food security/less hunger to a city or country
- h. strengthen security to battle fraud and other cyber-related crimes

Your written report should contain a brief description of the problem, the scope/cost of its impact and how a finance-related solution could effect meaningful change. You may wish to address cost savings, positive impact on lives, including specific, quantifiable benefits, feasibility and current obstacles.

Regardless of the option, properly cite at least 2 research resources (in addition to the textbook if you choose option 1) specific to the finance industry to support your conclusions.

Also, include at least 2 graphics (charts and/or tables) to support your argument. The total word count should be at least 800 words, but no more than 1,200 words.

Generally, I will assume the factors/details you cite in the report are accurate. Still, I will spot check and verify some statistics and/or sources you cite. I am most interested in how you write about these elements and how you choose to write and talk about them in your report and presentation.

Group Project Presentation

You and your teammates must give a presentation about the findings from your group project. Each person on the team must speak for at least a minute. The entire presentation must be longer than 10 minutes, but not longer than 15 minutes.

We will discuss ways to deliver a compelling presentation in class.

We also will discuss your group's options for presenting—either in-person during class or via a video recording. Regardless of the decision, all members of a group must present in the same way—either in person or via video recording. For example, you cannot have four members of your team present in class and one person present via video recording.

Evaluation of Another Team's Presentation

Using the Oral Communication rubric included with this syllabus, every student must evaluate each person in another group's presentation. Provide a number grade for each of the six categories and 2 positive comments for each speaker.

The instructor will assign the group to evaluate.

Quizzes

There are no quizzes for this class.

Exams

There is no final exam for this class. We will discuss key concepts during our last class.

Class Participation

Attendance and participation in class are mandatory. If you miss more than one class, contact me to discuss options. Students are expected to arrive on time for class, stay for the duration of class and engage with the instructor and fellow classmates during each class. The flexibility in the attendance policy that permits one class absence is designed to accommodate an emergency. Each person in every team must present during the Group Project presentation.

GRADING

Complete all assignments to earn a Satisfactory grade.

Assignments
Group Project Report
Group Project Slides
Group Project Presentation
Revised Project Written Report
Evaluation of Another Team's Presentation

You must complete all projects to pass.

S/U grades only for the course. But each assignment will be graded using the rubric shown in the Appendix of this syllabus.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

PREVENTION OF HARASSMENT AND DISCRIMINATION

The Office for the Prevention of Harassment & Discrimination (OPHD) provides assistance to students, faculty, and staff regarding reports of bias, harassment, and discrimination. OPHD is the UC San Diego Title IX office. Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 is the federal law that prohibits sex discrimination in educational institutions that are recipients of federal funds. Rady students have the right to an educational environment that is free from harassment and discrimination.

Students have options for reporting incidents of sexual violence and sexual harassment. Sexual violence includes sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, and stalking. Information about reporting options may be obtained at OPHD at (858) 534-8298, ophd@ucsd.edu or <http://ophd.ucsd.edu>. Students may receive confidential assistance at CARE at the Sexual Assault Resource Center at (858) 534-5793, sarc@ucsd.edu or <http://care.ucsd.edu> or Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at (858) 534-3755 or <http://caps.ucsd.edu>.

WRITING HELP AT UCSD

The Writing Hub at UCSD “supports all writers on campus—every writer, any project—and we promote writing as a tool for learning.” For more information, visit the website: <http://commons.ucsd.edu/students/writing/index.html>. Or contact someone at The Writing Hub via email at WritingHub@ucsd.edu or by phone: (858) 246-2110.

APPENDIX: GRADING

Grades:

A = Exceptional (22.1 to 25 points)

B = Good (20.1 to 22)

C = Acceptable (17.1 to 20)

D = Unacceptable (15.1 to 17)

*** This rubric provides a framework for how you will be evaluated in MGTF490, “Capstone Applied Finance Project.” S/U grades only for this course (MGTF417).**

Written Communication Grading Rubric

See the following Grading Rubric for guidance on how written assignments will be assessed.

A. Command of Topic

5	addresses the topic clearly and responds effectively to all aspects of the task
4	clearly addresses the topic, but may respond to some aspects of the task more effectively than others
3	addresses the topic, but may overlook or omit some aspects of the task
2	indicates confusion about the topic or neglects important aspects of the task
1	suggests an inability to comprehend the question or to respond meaningfully to the topic or task

B. Communication of Ideas

5	explores the issues thoughtfully and in depth, including relevant financial data; makes clear points
4	shows some depth and complexity of thought and general understanding of data
3	may treat the topic simplistically or repetitively or lack command of data; key point missing or muddled
2	lacks focus or fails to communicate ideas, both in text and graphic formats
1	is unfocused, illogical, incoherent, or disorganized

C. Organization

5	is coherently organized, with ideas supported by data and well-chosen examples
4	is well organized and developed with appropriate reasons, data and examples
3	is adequately organized and developed, generally supporting ideas with reasons, data and examples
2	is poorly organized and/or undeveloped and/or data does not support key ideas
1	is undeveloped; provides little or no relevant support

D. Syntactic and Data Variety

5	has an effective style marked by syntactic variety, ample data use and command of language
4	displays some syntactic variety in language and solid data use
3	demonstrates adequate facility with syntax and language and data use

2	has problems with or avoids syntactic variety or demonstrates inadequate sentence control and a limited vocabulary and lack of command of data
1	fails to display sentence control and uses a very limited vocabulary along with poor use of supporting data

E. Control of Mechanics

5	is generally free from errors in mechanics, usage, sentence structure and data use
4	may have a few errors in mechanics, usage, sentence structure and data use
3	Generally demonstrates control of mechanics, usage, sentence structure and data use
2	is marred by significant errors in mechanics, usage, sentence structure and data use
1	has serious and persistent errors in word choice, mechanics and use of data

Oral Communication Grading Rubric

	Criteria				Points
	4	3	2	1	
Relationship to Audience	Body language and strong eye contact invite dynamic relationship with audience.	Frequent eye contact. Notices and responds to audience.	Rarely looks up from notes or responds to audience.	No eye contact or response to audience.	
Body Language	Confident physical presence. Movements and gestures express content and desired relationship.	Solid physical base and appropriate movements or gestures that enhance delivery.	Movements are distracting; or presentation lacks clear movement or gestures.	Movement or gestures do not support content and relationship	
Voice	Vocal energy, varied inflection, and fluid speech express excitement and highlight key messages.	Satisfactory volume, clarity, and expression of ideas.	Weaker volume, expressiveness, or fluidity.	Consistently uses a monotone voice, hard to hear, no fluidity.	
Organization	Dramatically utilizes structure with strong opening, body, and closing. Stays focused throughout. Easy for audience to follow.	Organization provides variety and supports presentation objective. Loses focus no more than one time.	Has opening statement relevant to topic, and gives outline of speech. Mostly organized, provides an adequate "road map" for the listener. Loses focus no more than two times.	Introduction is undeveloped or irrelevant; main points and conclusion are unclear.	
Timing/Pace of the Presentation	Pace is consistently appropriate – completes presentation within allotted time, but not too early.	Pace is mostly appropriate – completes presentation within allotted time, but a little too early.	At times too fast - completes presentation within allotted time, but much too early.	Consistently too slow – does not complete presentation within time allowed.	
Content: Relevancy and Persuasiveness	Incorporates all relevant information in a persuasive manner; no irrelevant information given.	Incorporates most relevant information but is either lacking in persuasion or includes irrelevant information.	Lacks significant information.	Lacks significant information and persuasion; includes irrelevant information.	
				Total---->	

Scale: 22.1-24.0: Exceptional; 18.1-22.0: Good; 15.1-18.0: Acceptable; <15.0: Unacceptable.

*** This rubric provides a framework for how you will be evaluated in MGTF490, "Capstone Applied Finance Project." S/U grades only for this course (MGTF417).**